

## 4 An Unknown God

## Acts 17

Only a few short decades ago, Christians in the West could assume that most people they met belonged to a church or at least based their lives on Judeo-Christian values. Today, Christians in the West face what Christians in the East have had to cope with for centuries—a wide variety of religious beliefs and practices that often have little in common with Christianity. Paul left us a helpful model of how to cope with a world that cares so little about the truth when he visited the world center of pagan philosophy and religion—Athens.

GROUP DISCUSSION. What kinds of philosophies do you encounter in your family or at the university?

PERSONAL REFLECTION. Do you feel overwhelmed by the many philosophies and religions?

Remember and rejoice that Jesus is Lord over it all. In this passage we will observe how Paul responds to different cultures when he communicated the gospel. *Read Acts 17.*

1. Paul interacts with three cities and three different cultures. Compare Paul's ministry in Thessalonica and Berea. What approach did he take? How was his message received by the people? What kinds of results did he have?
2. What was Paul's message in summary? Why does that make sense?
3. Describe Paul's approach in Athens.
4. What are the main points of his lecture? Is it different from his message in Thessalonica? What is the final point?
5. How do the people of Athens respond to his teaching?

ABOUT US BRINGING THE GOSPEL: How to do this. A few questions to help us to focus.

6. Paul speaks of "the objects of your worship." What are some of the objects of worship for people in our culture?
7. In Athens Paul begins to tell them about the living God with an inscription from one of their altars—"TO AN UNKNOWN GOD." What are "points of truth" from which you can start to communicate the gospel to those in your world?
8. Paul's different approaches show his understanding of culture and his willingness to communicate with people where they are. What are the different groups or cultures that you interact with?
9. What are ways that you might be tempted to compromise the message of the gospel as you communicate it to certain people?
9. What do you need to do and know in order to more effectively communicate the good news about Jesus to people in your life from different cultures?

*Ask the Lord to show you what you have in common with the non-Christians in your life. Pray that you will effectively communicate the gospel to them.*

Look more closely at Paul's message to the people in Athens. Write down each example of where he connected with the culture. After the example write the points of truth that he made from each connection. Finally, think of one person with whom you would like to share the gospel. Write down how you might connect with them based on their culture and interests. Then write the points of truth that you might share based on the connection.